Fledge

The Wren Early Years Curriculum Framework — v0.2 (working draft)

A wren fledges when it is ready to leave the nest. Fledge is Wren's open curriculum framework for the Early Years Foundation Stage: a clear picture of what a child should take with them when they leave your setting, and the small steps that get them there from their very first day.

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Authorship: Written by practising early years professionals and refined in a working nursery. Not affiliated with, or a replacement for, the EYFS statutory framework — Fledge is non-statutory curriculum guidance, in the same category as Development Matters and Birth to 5 Matters, designed to be owned and edited by each setting.

How Fledge works

Fledge has three layers:

1. The Fledge Profile — 19 statements describing a child who is ready to fledge: what they know, can do, and have experienced by the time they leave for school. This is your curriculum intent on one page. Every setting is encouraged to edit it until every statement is true of *their* ambition for *their* children.

2. The progressions — for each of the seven EYFS areas of learning, a sequence of small steps across five overlapping bands from birth to school entry. Every band traces back to the Fledge Profile statements it is building towards (shown as → numbers). These are best-fit descriptions of typical development, not tick-lists or targets: children move through them at their own pace, and a child may sit in different bands for different areas.

3. The setting overlay — each setting localises Fledge: your community, your core books, your key experiences, your values, your name for it. In Wren, the overlay is data; the framework underneath stays shared.

The five bands

Band	Typical range	Typical room
1 — Nestlings	birth – 18 months	Baby room
2 — First flutters	18 months – 2½ years	Baby/toddler room
3 — Finding wings	2½ – 3½ years	Toddler/pre-school
4 — Stretching wings	3½ – 4½ years	Pre-school
5 — Ready to fledge	4½ years – school entry	Pre-school

Bands overlap deliberately. They describe the journey, not the rooms — use best-fit judgement, informed by everyday observation.

The seven areas

Prime areas (the foundations, dominant in bands 1–3): **Communication & Language** · **Personal, Social & Emotional Development** · **Physical Development**

Specific areas (built on the primes, growing through bands 3–5): **Literacy** · **Mathematics** · **Understanding the World** · **Expressive Arts & Design**

The characteristics of effective learning — playing and exploring, active learning, and creating and thinking critically — run through every band of every area and are deliberately embedded in Profile statements 5, 6 and 14.

The Seven Areas of Learning

Fledge follows the seven areas of learning and development set out in the EYFS statutory framework. The areas are a map of what childhood development covers, not a timetable — in real play a child moves through most of them before snack time. What follows is what each area is really about, why it earns its place, and what it looks like when provision is doing its job.

Communication & Language

Everything else is built on this. Language is how children think, make friends, manage feelings and, later, read and write — the size of a child's vocabulary at five is one of the strongest predictors of how school goes. The area covers three intertwined strands: **listening and attention** (tuning in, holding focus, following what's said), **understanding** (words, questions, instructions, ideas), and **speaking** (finding the words, joining them up, using them for real purposes — asking, telling, arguing, imagining).

The engine of it all is back-and-forth interaction: serve-and-return conversation from the babble stage onwards, adults who narrate, wonder aloud, add words to what the child is doing, and genuinely listen. A language-rich setting is not a noisy one — it's one where every child is spoken *with*, not *at*, many times a day, and where songs, rhymes and stories are constant companions. → Profile 1, 2, 3, 14.

Personal, Social & Emotional Development

The foundations of mental health are laid here, and nothing in the specific areas compensates if they're shaky. PSED covers a child's **sense of self** (identity, confidence, independence, pride in effort), their **feelings** (naming them, riding them out, the slow journey from being regulated by an adult to regulating themselves), and their **relationships** (attachment to key people, then friendship, empathy, fairness and belonging to a community).

It grows out of warm, consistent, responsive care — the key person relationship is the curriculum here, especially for the youngest children. Boundaries held kindly, feelings taken seriously, conflict treated as a teaching moment rather than a nuisance, and adults who model the kindness they hope to see. British values live here too, at nursery scale: taking turns, having a voice, agreeing the rules, respecting difference. → Profile 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, 10, 11.

Physical Development

Movement is not a break from learning — it *is* learning. Gross motor control (core strength, balance, coordination, stamina) comes first and everything finer hangs off it: a child who can't yet sit steadily can't control a pencil, and the road to writing runs through climbing frames, crawling, carrying heavy things and swinging on monkey bars. Fine motor control (grasping, threading, pouring, snipping, mark-making) follows, built through hundreds of hours of purposeful hand use — dough, tools, buttons, spoons.

The area also owns **self-care and health**: feeding themselves, dressing, toileting, sleep, handwashing, tasting a wide range of foods, and beginning to know what their own body needs. Daily energetic movement, indoors and out, in all weathers, is the baseline entitlement. → Profile 4, 18, 19.

Literacy

Loving books comes first; the mechanics come later and land better because of it. Early literacy is three things growing together: **comprehension** (understanding and enjoying stories, talking about them, retelling and inventing them — built entirely through being read with, long before reading), **early word reading** (playing with sounds and rhymes, tuning the ear, then — at the very top end — linking sounds to letters and blending

simple words), and **early writing** (mark-making with meaning: the journey from banging a crayon to “that says my name”).

A core canon of deeply-known books does more than a shelf of hundreds skimmed once: children need to meet the same stories again and again until they own them. Phonics in the nursery years is playful and oral; the formal scheme is school’s job — our job is to send children there desperate to crack the code. → Profile 2, 15, 16.

Mathematics

Early maths is about **number sense**, not counting recitals: knowing that the last number said is *how many*, seeing two or three at a glance without counting, watching how small quantities combine and come apart, and comparing more, less and the same in arguments that matter (usually about snack). Alongside number sits **spatial reasoning, shape, pattern and measure** — filling and emptying, fitting things into spaces, building, spotting and making patterns, and the rich language of position, size and weight.

It’s learned through play and routines, never worksheets: laying the table, sharing the strawberries, counting the stairs. The adult’s job is to notice the maths already in the play and give it words — and to hand on a simple attitude: maths is interesting, and you are good at it. → Profile 17.

Understanding the World

This is the area where the child’s world gets bigger. It covers the **natural world** (growing, seasons, weather, creatures, materials and how they change — science as wonder, with gentle hands), **people and communities** (their own family and story, then other families, faiths, languages and ways of living — met as interesting, never as strange), the **past and present** (“when I was a baby…”, the people who help us, how things used to be), and the child’s **local patch** — the park, the shops, the library, the buses, explored as a learner, not just passed through.

For a setting like ours, the community *is* the curriculum: home languages heard with pride, food from many kitchens, festivals beyond your own, and real outings with real purposes. → Profile 9, 11, 12, 13, 14.

Expressive Arts & Design

Children think with their hands and imaginations before they can think in the abstract. This area covers **making** in every medium — paint, dough, junk, blocks, fabric, sound — where the process matters far more than the product; **music and movement** — a wide repertoire of songs, playing with rhythm and volume, dancing because the music demands it; and **imaginative play** — from feeding teddy to sprawling multi-day storylines with roles, rules and negotiated props, which is where language, social skill and narrative all rehearse together.

The adult’s job is to protect it: open-ended materials, unhurried time, and restraint — no adult-drawn templates, no “what is it?”, and genuine interest in what the child meant to make. Creativity here is a habit of mind — having ideas and the nerve to try them — not a display for the wall. → Profile 2, 5, 6.

SEND — Every Child Fledges

Fledge describes *typical* development, and plenty of children don't develop typically. The framework is written so that this is information, never a verdict.

The bands are not ages. A four-year-old whose communication best fits Band 2 is not "behind the curriculum" — the curriculum for that child *is* Band 2, delivered with the dignity of their actual age and interests. Best-fit banding per area works unchanged for children with SEND, and often works better: it shows the spiky profile (Band 4 physical, Band 2 communication) that a single "age band" hides, and that spikiness is the planning document.

Smaller steps. For some children the distance between two Fledge statements is a term's work, and progress lives in the space between them. Any statement can be broken into smaller next steps — "Joins in favourite songs with words and actions" might become *tolerates the song being sung near them → watches and stills → does one action → anticipates the action coming*. Sideways progress counts too: doing a known skill in a new place, with a new person, or without a prompt is real progress and gets celebrated as such. Smaller steps are written by the people who know the child, ideally with the professionals around them — Fledge deliberately doesn't ship a bank of them, because the right small step is specific to the child.

The graduated approach. Fledge slots into the assess–plan–do–review cycle from the SEND Code of Practice (2015): knowledge of the child (assess) → a few smaller steps and the provision changes to get there (plan) → everyday practice (do) → did it work, honestly? (review). Parents are partners in every cycle, the SENCO holds the thread, and outside professionals' targets (speech and language, portage, OT) sit alongside Fledge steps rather than competing with them.

Environment before programmes. The first adaptation is almost never a scheme — it's the room: fewer transitions, more visual routine, quieter corners, motivating materials, an adult who waits longer. Most children on an early-years SEND journey need the ordinary curriculum delivered extraordinarily well, not a different curriculum.

In Wren. The SEN register holds needs, EHCP and review dates, external professionals and the provision map; a child's smaller steps live as their individual targets, linked (optionally, as ever) to the Fledge statement they build towards; and because frameworks in Wren are pluggable, a setting can run a specialist framework (e.g. an engagement-model-style approach for a child working below Band 1 patterns) alongside Fledge for the children who need it. Recording stays knowledge-first: write what's worth remembering and what the review cycle needs — no evidence-hunting.

Statutory anchors: SEND Code of Practice 0–25 (2015); Equality Act 2010 (reasonable adjustments); EYFS statutory framework (SENCO arrangements and equal opportunities).

The Fledge Profile

What a child who has spent their early years with us takes to school

Underpinning all of it: every child leaves us known — by name, by interest, by family — and knowing that the adults here delighted in them.

COMMUNICATION & CONNECTION

1. **Speaks up and is understood.** Can hold a back-and-forth conversation with an adult they trust, tell a simple story about their own life, and ask for help with words.
2. **Has a rich bank of stories and songs.** Knows our core books deeply — can join in, retell, and argue about the ending. Knows 15+ songs and rhymes by heart.
3. **Resolves a squabble with words first.** Can say "stop, I don't like it," negotiate a turn, and accept that someone else got there first — most of the time.

INDEPENDENCE & SELF

1. **Manages their own body and belongings.** Puts on their own coat and shoes, manages the toilet independently, finds their own peg, pours their own drink, has a go at buttons and zips.
2. **Keeps trying when it's hard.** Sticks with a tricky puzzle, tower or drawing long enough to feel the win — and can say "I did it!" rather than waiting to be rescued.
3. **Makes real choices and owns them.** Chooses where to play, what to make, and can say why. Knows their ideas matter here.
4. **Knows their own feelings have names.** Can tell a trusted adult they're sad, cross or worried, and has at least one thing that helps them calm.

KINDNESS & COMMUNITY

1. **Notices how others feel — and acts on it.** Fetches a tissue for a crying friend, makes room at the table, checks on someone who fell over. Kindness is a habit here, not a rule.
2. **Treats living things gently.** Handles minibeasts with care, waters the plants, knows that animals, insects and growing things can be hurt and deserve our protection.
3. **Understands fairness and has a voice.** Takes turns, votes on the story at group time, helps agree our room rules and mostly keeps to them — and knows that everyone gets a say, even when we disagree. *(Democracy, rule of law and individual liberty, at nursery scale.)*
4. **Respects people who are different from them.** Knows that families, faiths, languages and ways of living vary — in our setting and our community — and that different is interesting, not wrong. *(Mutual respect and tolerance.)*

CURIOSITY & THE WORLD

1. **Has grown something, cooked something, and cared for something living.** Planted and harvested, mixed and baked, and helped look after a plant or creature.
2. **Knows their local patch.** Has been to the park, the shops, the library and beyond as a learner — noticed the transport, the seasons, the people who help us. Has heard home languages spoken with pride, tasted food from many kitchens, and marked festivals beyond their own.
3. **Asks real questions and expects real answers.** "Why?" is welcomed here, and children leave still asking it.

EARLY LITERACY & MATHS

1. **Loves books enough to choose them.** Picks up a book unprompted, handles it correctly, and "reads" it to a friend or teddy.
2. **Makes marks with meaning.** Draws, paints and "writes" with purpose — and can tell you what it says. Recognises their own name.
3. **Plays with number naturally.** Counts things that matter to them (snack, steps, friends), spots patterns, compares more/less, and uses maths talk in play without being asked.

BODY & WELLBEING

1. **Moves with confidence.** Runs, climbs, balances, throws and catches; uses scissors, threads, and pours with growing control.
2. **Knows what their body needs.** Understands hungry, thirsty, tired and cold — and does something about it. Washes hands without a fuss. Tried (or at least met) a wide range of foods.

The Progressions — Prime Areas

Communication & Language

Band 1 — Nestlings (birth–18m) → *builds towards 1, 2* - Turns towards familiar voices and interesting sounds; watches faces intently when spoken to. - Takes turns in babble “conversations” — vocalises, pauses, waits for a reply. - Responds to their own name and to familiar words in routines (“milk”, “nappy”, “up”). - Uses gesture, pointing and first words to show wants and share attention (“look!”). - Enjoys songs, rhymes and simple books shared one-to-one; shows anticipation of familiar refrains.

Band 2 — First flutters (18m–2½) → *builds towards 1, 2* - Understands and follows simple one-step instructions in context (“get your cup”). - Vocabulary growing fast; joins two to three words into little sentences (“more milk please”). - Joins in favourite songs and rhymes with words and actions; asks for them by name. - Names familiar people, objects and pictures; begins asking simple questions (“what’s that?”). - Listens to short stories one-to-one and points things out along the way.

Band 3 — Finding wings (2½–3½) → *builds towards 1, 2, 14* - Follows two-part instructions (“find your coat and bring it here”). - Talks in longer sentences and uses talk within play — narrating, directing, pretending. - Asks lots of questions — why, what, where — and expects answers. - Retells familiar stories loosely, with props, puppets or pictures. - Is understood by unfamiliar adults most of the time, with some immaturities still typical.

Band 4 — Stretching wings (3½–4½) → *builds towards 1, 2, 3* - Listens and responds in small-group times; can shift attention when supported. - Uses longer, joined sentences with tenses and connectives (errors still normal: “runned”). - Tells their own stories and recounts real events in rough sequence. - Picks up and tries out new vocabulary from stories and topics. - Holds a genuine back-and-forth conversation on a topic of interest across several turns.

Band 5 — Ready to fledge (4½–school) → *delivers 1, 2, 3* - Holds sustained conversations with adults and peers, listening and responding to what others say. - Tells a coherent story about their own life with a beginning, middle and end. - Uses talk to negotiate, explain thinking, imagine and resolve disagreements. - Asks for help with words and asks what unfamiliar words mean. - Owns a wide repertoire of stories, songs and rhymes and uses their language in play.

Personal, Social & Emotional Development

Band 1 — Nestlings (birth–18m) → *builds towards 7, 8* - Builds a warm bond with their key person; settles and is comforted by familiar adults. - Expresses emotions clearly through face, body and voice; soothes with co-regulation. - Shows real interest in other babies and children — watches, reaches, smiles. - Shows an emerging sense of self: responds to name, explores their reflection. - Uses their trusted adult as a safe base to explore from and return to.

Band 2 — First flutters (18m–2½) → *builds towards 5, 6, 7* - Separates from their carer with support from a familiar adult; settles into the day. - Plays alongside other children, watching and copying; beginning moments of shared play. - Feels feelings at full volume; calms with adult co-regulation and comfort. - Shows growing determination and independence — “me do it!” — and pride in doing so. - Beginning to understand simple boundaries with warm, consistent reminders.

Band 3 — Finding wings (2½–3½) → *builds towards 3, 7, 8, 10* - Moves from alongside-play into early cooperative play with familiar children. - Takes turns with adult support; beginning to wait, sometimes gracefully. - Names basic feelings in themselves and in pictures/stories (happy, sad, cross). - Follows the room’s rhythms and rules with reminders; helps with tidying and routines. - Copies the kindness modelled around them — pats, hugs, fetching things for others.

Band 4 — Stretching wings (3½–4½) → *builds towards 3, 5, 7, 8, 10* - Plays cooperatively with roles and shared ideas; keeps play going by negotiating. - Resolves minor conflicts with adult scaffolding, increasingly

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reaching for words first. - Talks about feelings, what caused them, and what helps them feel better. - Shows genuine empathy — notices and comforts a sad or hurt friend unprompted. - Grows in confidence in groups: contributes ideas, tries new things, persists at challenges.

Band 5 — Ready to fledge (4½–school) *→ delivers 3, 5, 6, 7, 8, 10* - Forms real friendships and knows how to be a good friend. - Resolves squabbles with words first, most of the time; accepts not always getting their way. - Regulates big feelings using strategies that work for them, with adults nearby not in charge. - Contributes to group decisions, takes turns fairly, and keeps to agreed rules — and expects others to. - Shows kindness habitually and takes visible pride in effort and achievement — “I did it!”

Physical Development

Band 1 — Nestlings (birth–18m) *→ builds towards 18, 19* - Gains control of their body in sequence: rolling, sitting, crawling, cruising, first steps. - Reaches, grasps, transfers and releases objects; explores with hands and mouth. - Feeds themselves finger foods; holds their own cup or bottle with help. - Explores freely with their whole body — climbing over, crawling through, pulling up. - Sleeps, feeds and settles into predictable rhythms with responsive care.

Band 2 — First flutters (18m–2½) *→ builds towards 4, 18, 19* - Walks confidently, runs, squats to play and climbs low furniture and steps. - Kicks and throws a ball; pushes, pulls and carries big things on purpose. - Makes marks with whole-arm and fist movements; enjoys dough, water, sand with hands. - Feeds themselves with a spoon and drinks from an open cup with spills. - Cooperates with dressing and nappy changes; begins to notice toileting needs.

Band 3 — Finding wings (2½–3½) *→ builds towards 4, 18, 19* - Jumps with two feet, scoots or pedals, balances on low equipment with support. - Snips with scissors; grip moving from fist towards fingers for mark-making. - Pours, spreads, threads large beads and uses one-handed tools with growing control. - Manages toileting with support and reminders; washes hands as part of the routine. - Helps dress themselves — arms in sleeves, pulls up trousers, has a go at shoes.

Band 4 — Stretching wings (3½–4½) *→ builds towards 4, 18, 19* - Runs with control, hops, catches a large ball, and negotiates space and obstacles well. - Cuts along a line with scissors; draws with an effective, comfortable grip. - Uses tools with intent — brushes, glue spreaders, cutlery, small construction. - Uses the toilet independently; manages most dressing with minimal help. - Talks about being hungry, thirsty, tired, hot or cold — and acts on it with prompts.

Band 5 — Ready to fledge (4½–school) *→ delivers 4, 18, 19* - Runs, climbs, balances, throws and catches with confidence and control. - Uses scissors, threading, pouring and small tools with precision and patience. - Manages coat, shoes and buttons; toilets and washes hands independently, without a fuss. - Knows what their body needs — food, drink, rest, warmth, movement — and does something about it. - Has tried (or at least met) a wide range of foods, and moves every day because it feels good.

The Progressions — Specific Areas

Literacy

Band 1 — Nestlings (birth–18m) → *builds towards 2, 15* - Enjoys books shared one-to-one; pats, points at and mouths sturdy books. - Responds with delight to rhymes, rhythm and songs; anticipates the good bits. - Handles books with growing purpose — holds, turns chunky pages, chooses favourites. - Makes marks in sensory materials — food, water, paint — and notices the effect.

Band 2 — First flutters (18m–2½) → *builds towards 2, 15, 16* - Chooses favourite books again and again; turns pages and holds books the right way up. - Joins in with repeated refrains and fills in the missing word ("…you can't catch me!"). - Points at and names pictures; links pictures to their own life ("my dog!"). - Makes marks freely and begins to give them meaning after the fact.

Band 3 — Finding wings (2½–3½) → *builds towards 2, 14, 15, 16* - Talks about stories — what's happening, what might happen next, what they liked. - Notices print in the world: logos, signs, their name card, familiar labels. - Draws with intent — "it's mummy" — and distinguishes drawing from "writing". - Joins in rhyming games and notices rhythm; claps along to syllables in songs.

Band 4 — Stretching wings (3½–4½) → *builds towards 2, 15, 16* - Retells familiar stories with structure — beginning, middle, end — and invents variations. - Tunes into sounds: hears rhyme, initial sounds and syllables in playful games. - Beginning early phonics: recognises a few Phase 2 sounds and links them to letters in play. - Writes some letter-like shapes and attempts their own name; "writes" lists and cards in play. - "Reads" books to friends, teddies or themselves, using pictures and memory.

Band 5 — Ready to fledge (4½–school) → *delivers 2, 15, 16* - Chooses books unprompted, handles them correctly, and loves particular authors and stories. - Retells known stories richly and invents their own; argues about endings. - Recognises their own name and a growing set of Phase 2 sounds; at the very top end, blends sounds to read simple CVC words (cat, dog, sun). - Writes their name and makes marks with communicated meaning — labels, cards, signs in play. - Knows the setting's core stories deeply enough to make them their own.

Mathematics

Band 1 — Nestlings (birth–18m) → *builds towards 17* - Explores objects deeply: in and out, stacking, dropping, banging, posting. - Responds to number songs and finger rhymes with delight. - Notices "more" — and asks for it in their own way. - Explores space with their body: over, under, inside, behind.

Band 2 — First flutters (18m–2½) → *builds towards 17* - Says some number words in play and song, not always in order — and that's fine. - Sorts and groups objects by what matters to them (all the cars, all the red ones). - Loves filling, emptying, hiding and finding; builds and knocks down. - Uses early size and quantity words: big, little, more, all gone.

Band 3 — Finding wings (2½–3½) → *builds towards 17* - Counts small groups with growing accuracy; gives you "two" when asked. - Matches, sorts and notices what's the same and different. - Fits shapes into spaces, builds with purpose, completes inset puzzles. - Compares amounts and sizes in play: more/less, big/little, lots/not many.

Band 4 — Stretching wings (3½–4½) → *builds towards 17* - Counts objects with one-to-one correspondence beyond five; knows the last number is the answer. - Subitises small amounts — sees two or three without counting. - Copies, continues and creates simple patterns; talks about them. - Uses positional and comparative language in play: behind, next to, longer, heavier, full.

Band 5 — Ready to fledge (4½–school) → *delivers 17* - Counts things that matter to them — snack, steps, friends — naturally and accurately. - Subitises to three and beyond; explores how small numbers combine and separate in play. - Spots, makes and extends patterns; predicts what comes next. - Uses maths talk in play without being asked, and solves real problems (sharing the snack fairly).

Understanding the World

Band 1 — Nestlings (birth–18m) → *builds towards 9, 12, 13* - Explores natural materials and treasure baskets with all their senses. - Notices and delights in familiar people; studies new faces carefully. - Notices the world on outings — wind, leaves, dogs, buses — from pram or carrier. - Anticipates familiar routines and shows they know what comes next.

Band 2 — First flutters (18m–2½) → *builds towards 9, 12, 13* - Points out animals, plants and vehicles on walks; wants to touch, smell, chase. - Explores how things work: buttons, flaps, hinges, switches, containers. - Knows familiar people beyond their family — nursery friends and adults, neighbours, shopkeepers. - Watches living things with fascination; learns “gentle” with hands-on modelling.

Band 3 — Finding wings (2½–3½) → *builds towards 9, 12, 13, 14* - Shows care for plants and creatures with reminders — watering, gentle hands, quiet feet. - Talks about what they see and find on local walks; collects treasures. - Notices weather and seasons and what they mean for us (coats, puddles, sun cream). - Asks questions about the world around them and expects real answers.

Band 4 — Stretching wings (3½–4½) → *builds towards 9, 11, 12, 13, 14* - Plants, harvests, mixes and bakes; helps care for living things as a responsibility. - Talks about their own family and notices that other families are different — and interesting. - Remembers and compares past and present (“when I was a baby…”). - Explores forces, materials and change through play — melting, mixing, floating, growing.

Band 5 — Ready to fledge (4½–school) → *delivers 9, 11, 12, 13, 14* - Has grown something, cooked something, and cared for something living — and can tell you about it. - Knows their local patch as a learner: the park, the shops, the library, the people who help us. - Treats living things gently as a matter of course, and expects others to. - Knows that families, faiths, languages and ways of living vary — and that different is interesting, not wrong. - Asks real questions, makes predictions, and still says “why?”

Expressive Arts & Design

Band 1 — Nestlings (birth–18m) → *builds towards 2, 6* - Explores sound, texture and colour with their whole body. - Responds to music — stills, bounces, sways, vocalises along. - Explores paint, water and messy materials for the joy of the sensation. - Copies simple actions in songs and games — clap, wave, peekaboo.

Band 2 — First flutters (18m–2½) → *builds towards 2, 6* - Joins in songs with actions and asks for favourites again and again. - Explores paint, dough, sand and glue with enthusiasm and their own agenda. - Pretends briefly with real-looking props: feeds teddy, stirs the pot, phones nanny. - Makes sounds on purpose — bangs, shakes, taps — and enjoys the effect.

Band 3 — Finding wings (2½–3½) → *builds towards 2, 5, 6* - Role plays familiar scenes — home, shop, doctor — with props and friends nearby. - Builds and constructs with purpose and tells you about it. - Sings familiar songs from memory, sometimes to themselves in play. - Makes choices about colours, materials and tools, and mixes to see what happens.

Band 4 — Stretching wings (3½–4½) → *builds towards 2, 5, 6* - Sustains imaginative play with others: shared storylines, assigned roles, negotiated props. - Creates with a plan — “I’m making a rocket” — and adapts when it doesn’t work. - Learns new songs quickly and experiments with rhythm, volume and silly versions. - Talks about their own creations and notices detail in others’ work.

Band 5 — Ready to fledge (4½–school) → *delivers 2, 5, 6* - Invents rich pretend play with narratives, characters and rules — and keeps it going over time. - Makes real choices about what to create and how, and owns the result proudly. - Sings a wide repertoire and moves, plays and performs with confidence. - Represents their ideas across many media — drawing, building, dancing, storying — and sticks with tricky makes until they feel the win.

Assessment in Fledge

Assessment in Fledge is professional knowledge, not data collection. The people who know a child best are the practitioners who spend every day with them — and that knowledge, held in their heads, *is* the assessment. The framework exists to give that knowledge a shared language, not to generate paperwork.

- **Knowing the child is the evidence.** If a practitioner can talk confidently about where a child is and what they need next, the assessment has already happened. Nothing needs to be written down to make it real.
- **Tagging is a choice, never a requirement.** Fledge never requires observations to be tagged, tracked or matched to statements — a statement never needs an observation attached to prove it. Settings that find linking observations to the progression useful can switch it on in Wren; settings that don't, simply won't see it. The framework recommends knowledge-first; the choice belongs to the setting.
- **Write only what's worth remembering.** Record the moments that genuinely tell you something new, the ones parents will treasure, and what's needed for statutory points (the two-year progress check, transition to school). Everything else is time better spent with children.
- **Best-fit banding, per area, from knowledge.** Periodically, a practitioner places each child in the band that best describes them for each area — a professional judgement made in minutes from what they already know, usually different bands for different areas, and that's information, not a problem.
- **The Profile is the destination, not a test.** The 19 statements are curriculum intent for the whole cohort, not an individual checklist.
- **Gaps drive planning.** Where knowledge of the children says an area is thin, provision changes — that is the whole point of the loop.

This approach follows the principles set out in Birth to 5 Matters: assessment should serve children's learning, draw on practitioners' professional knowledge, and never become an exercise in generating data for its own sake. Wren's job is to make the small amount of recording that IS worth doing as fast as possible — not to demand more of it.

The Setting Overlay

Every Fledge setting localises the framework without forking it. The overlay defines:

- **Your patch** — the actual park, library, market and streets in statement 13 and the UW progressions.
- **Your core books and songs** — the specific canon behind statements 2 and 15 (recommended: 10–20 core books, 15+ songs, chosen by your team).
- **Your phonics programme** — the Literacy progressions reference “Phase 2” sounds and CVC blending using Letters and Sounds/Little Wandle terminology; map these to your own scheme’s equivalent stage if you use a different programme.
- **Your key experiences** — your version of grown/cooked/cared-for (12): the herb planter, the sourdough, the snails.
- **Your festivals and community** — which celebrations, whose home languages, which visitors.
- **Your words** — rename bands, rewrite statements, add your values. The framework is the skeleton; the setting is the voice.

In Wren, the overlay lives as setting-level data on top of the shared framework, so updates to Fledge never overwrite what makes your setting yours.

And Fledge itself is a choice. Wren ships with Fledge, but frameworks in Wren are pluggable: a setting can adopt Fledge as-is, adapt it, build their own framework from scratch, or recreate the structure of another published framework (such as Birth to 5 Matters or Development Matters) for their own internal use — the same way many settings have built custom frameworks inside other platforms for years. Your curriculum, your framework, your call.

Fledge v0.2 — working draft. v0.2 adds the Seven Areas of Learning descriptions and the SEND section. Statutory coverage check against the EYFS framework (educational programmes + ELGs) to be completed before external release.